

NATIONAL RESEARCH CENTRE ON CAMEL, BIKANER

DESERT STORMTROOPER

If camel kulfi is becoming a fad among the tourists, the credit goes to the National Research Centre on Camel (NRCC), Bikaner. Just three years back, breeders were selling camels to butchers because of the Indira Gandhi canal and the elimination of free grazing pastures, forcing people to question the existence of the NRCC. "From the basic work of conserving and improving the breed, we reoriented ourselves to making the camel attractive to owners," says Director K.M.L. Pathak. The change in approach began yielding results. The centre opened a milk parlour on its campus this year, selling Kumbhat Kulfi, a name for the camel in Sanskrit, flavoured milk, coffee and tea, all made of camel milk. Then the Rajasthan Cooperative Dairy Federation stepped in by marketing its products. The centre is creating milk powder and cheese from camel milk and has already developed

bitter cheese. Now, even private entrepreneurs are cashing in on the success story. Joru Ram Raika of Jhunjhunu district has set up a dairy in Bikaner where he sells the milk for up to Rs 22 a kg as against Rs 16 by the cooperative. An NRI Arjun Batra, who is working for a firm which is into milk production, has asked the centre to help him identify land in Bikaner to set up a camel milk dairy. NRCC is also collaborating with the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre and Lilavati Hospital, Mumbai, to assess the therapeutic value of camel antibodies. Camels are being used to make antidotes for snake venom and Dubai wants to collaborate on research in camel diseases. With a 700-hectare campus on the Bikaner-Jodhpur highway, and 300 camels from four pure single-humped breeds, the institute has proved to be as hardy as the animal.

by Rohit Parihar

Rs 10 lakh

The amount earned by NRCC through the sale of entry tickets to tourists last year.

Two hours: The time taken to charge a 12-volt battery through camel power.

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

LAND OF MILK: Pathak on a camel-powered machine

"This is the only" institute in the world doing research on every aspect of the camel."

K. M. L. PATHAK, DIRECTOR, NRCC

